

What Is the Age of Drift?

How Modern Systems Gradually Lose Contact with Reality

Reality Drift Framework — Representational Systems Brief #7

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The Basic Pattern

Most systems do not fail because they suddenly break.

They fail because they gradually become more responsive to their own representations than to the realities they were created to represent.

This process is called **Reality Drift**.

The basic sequence is:

reality → representation → optimization → weakened constraints → drift

The system continues operating.

The metrics remain stable.

The procedures continue.

The representations stay internally consistent.

Yet the connection to reality slowly weakens.

Why It Happens

Modern societies depend on representation.

Information becomes databases.

Students become grades.

Patients become charts.

Workers become dashboards.

Communities become statistics.

Financial health becomes quarterly reports.

Representation is necessary.

Large societies could not function without it.

The problem begins when these representations stop behaving as measurements and begin behaving as reality itself.

How Drift Spreads

The same structural pattern appears across very different domains.

In education, grades begin replacing learning.

In work, performance indicators replace productive work.

In healthcare, documentation competes with patient care.

In finance, quarterly metrics dominate long-term resilience.

Online, engagement becomes a substitute for value.

In everyday life, profiles increasingly replace people.

Different systems.

The same mechanism.

Why Drift Is Difficult to Notice

Reality Drift is usually invisible while it is happening.

Each individual adjustment appears reasonable.

A new metric improves accountability.

A new dashboard improves visibility.

A new policy improves consistency.

A new optimization improves efficiency.

No single decision creates the problem.

The distance accumulates gradually across thousands of small changes.

By the time the gap becomes obvious, the system has already reorganized itself around the new representation.

The Age of Drift

The defining challenge of modern life is not simply misinformation, bureaucracy, AI, or institutional failure.

It is that more and more systems now operate primarily through representations.

As those representations become easier to optimize than reality itself, the same pattern begins appearing everywhere.

Different technologies.

Different institutions.

Different cultures.

One underlying structure.

This is the Age of Drift.

Reality Drift

Reality Drift describes the gradual loss of alignment between representations and the realities they were created to describe.

The process is rarely intentional.

It emerges whenever systems optimize what they can represent more effectively than what they can directly observe.

Over time, representations begin shaping one another while reality provides weaker and weaker corrective feedback.

The system remains coherent.

It may even appear successful.

The absence of failure is not proof of alignment.

The Core Principle

Reality rarely disappears all at once.

It is gradually replaced by increasingly optimized representations of itself.

Most systems do not collapse.

They drift.

The gap widens slowly.

Then all at once.

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